

SRA-001 Module 2: History of Cupping Around the World

Student Workbook

Student Name: _____

Cohort: _____

Date: _____

Module Overview

This workbook accompanies Module 2 of the SRA-001 Certified Hijama Practitioner programme. Complete all exercises, case studies, and reflection prompts to reinforce your learning.

Learning Objectives Checklist

By the end of this module, you will be able to:

- Trace the documented history of cupping from ancient Egypt to the present day
 - Describe the contributions of Egyptian, Chinese, and Greek civilisations to cupping therapy
 - Analyse the contributions of key Islamic scholars to Hijama literature
 - Explain the methodology of Ibn al-Qayyim and the significance of Zad al-Ma'ad
 - Evaluate the impact of colonialism on traditional medicine and the modern revival
 - Apply source criticism to historical claims about cupping
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Exercise 1: Ancient Egypt

1.1 The Ebers Papyrus (c. 1550 BCE) is significant because:

1.2 What was the Egyptian concept of “metu” and how did it relate to cupping?

1.3 List three other ancient Egyptian medical papyri:

1. _____
 2. _____
 3. _____
-

Exercise 2: Ancient China

2.1 What is “ba guan” and what does it mean literally?

2.2 Complete the instrument evolution timeline:

Animal horns → _____ → _____ → _____ → _____ → Modern plastic

2.3 How did TCM theory explain the mechanism of cupping?

Exercise 3: Ancient Greece

3.1 What was the four humours theory and how did it explain cupping’s effect?

3.2 Name three Greek figures who wrote about cupping and their key contributions:

Figure	Dates	Contribution

3.3 How did the Greek systematic approach to cupping (diagnosis → indication → contraindication → technique → follow-up) influence modern practice?

Exercise 4: The SRA Historical Timeline

4.1 Complete the timeline with key events:

Date	Civilisation	Key Event
c. 1550 BCE	Egypt	
c. 400 BCE	Greece	
281 CE	China	
7th-13th c.	Islamic Golden Age	
18th-19th c.	Global	

Table 2 – continued

Date	Civilisation	Key Event
Late 20th c.	Global	
2022	Global	

Exercise 5: Islamic Scholars

5.1 Match each scholar to their contribution:

Scholar	Key Work	Contribution
Ibn Sina (980–1037)	Al-Qanun fi al-Tibb	
Al-Zahrawi (936–1013)	Al-Tasrif	
Al-Razi (854–925)	Al-Hawi fi al-Tibb	
Ibn al-Qayyim (1292–1350)	Zad al-Ma’ ad	

5.2 What four-step scholarly methodology did these scholars share?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Exercise 6: Ibn al-Qayyim and Zad al-Ma’ad

6.1 Why is Zad al-Ma’ad considered the foundational text for Hijama practitioners?

6.2 What were Ibn al-Qayyim’s five key contributions to Hijama scholarship?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

6.3 How did Ibn al-Qayyim’s methodology differ from scholars who merely repeated tradition?

Exercise 7: Decline and Revival

7.1 What four factors contributed to the decline of traditional medicine during the colonial period?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

7.2 What four factors have driven the modern revival of Hijama?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

7.3 Describe the current state of Hijama in your region:

Exercise 8: Source Criticism

8.1 A website claims cupping was practised in “ancient Sumeria 5,000 years ago.” How would you evaluate this claim using the SRA source criticism framework?

8.2 Why is it important for practitioners to distinguish between verified historical claims and speculation?

Case Study 1: The Skeptical Colleague

Scenario:

You are at a healthcare networking event. A physiotherapist approaches you and says: “Cupping is just a placebo with a long history. There’s no real evidence it works, and the ‘history’ is just marketing to make it seem legitimate.”

Questions:

1. **Historical Response:** How do you respond to the claim that cupping’s history is “just marketing”?

2. **Evidence Response:** What research evidence could you cite (from this module and Module 1)?

3. **Professional Response:** How do you maintain professionalism while defending your practice?

Case Study 2: The Traditionalist Patient

Scenario:

A patient tells you: “My grandmother says Hijama should only be done on the 17th, 19th, and 21st days of the lunar month. She says doing it on other days is harmful. She also says you must use glass cups — plastic cups have no benefit.”

Questions:

1. **Historical Context:** What is the basis for the Sunnah day recommendation? Is it from the Prophet (peace be upon him) or from later tradition?

2. **Evidence Evaluation:** Is there clinical evidence that plastic cups are less effective than glass cups?

3. **Communication:** How do you respect the patient’s grandmother’s wisdom while providing evidence-informed care?

Reflect–Learn–Apply Journal

Reflection Prompt 1: Standing on the Shoulders of Giants

Reflect: How does knowing that scholars like Ibn al-Qayyim spent their lives perfecting Hijama knowledge affect your attitude toward learning?

Learn: What is one historical insight that changes how you think about your practice?

Apply: What is one commitment you make to honour this scholarly tradition?

Reflection Prompt 2: The Responsibility of Revival

Reflect: The colonial period caused massive loss of medical knowledge. How does this history affect your understanding of your role as a contemporary practitioner?

Learn: What does “evidence-informed professionalism” mean in the context of Hijama’s history?

Apply: How will you contribute to the preservation and advancement of Hijama knowledge?

Knowledge Check: Module 2

Multiple Choice

1. The earliest written record of cupping therapy is found in:

- a) The Hippocratic Corpus
- b) The Ebers Papyrus
- c) Zad al-Ma’ad
- d) Zhao Xuemin’s writings

Answer: _____

2. Ibn al-Qayyim’s Zad al-Ma’ad is significant because it:

- a) Was the first text to mention cupping

- b) Combined authentic Hadith with clinical observation
- c) Was written in Greek and translated into Arabic
- d) Focused only on dry cupping

Answer: _____

3. The four humours in Greek medicine were:

- a) Blood, phlegm, black bile, yellow bile
- b) Blood, qi, lymph, mucus
- c) Air, fire, water, earth
- d) Metu, channels, vessels, nerves

Answer: _____

4. Which factor did NOT contribute to the decline of traditional medicine during the colonial period?

- a) Colonial suppression of indigenous systems
- b) Closure of bimaristans and madrasas
- c) The translation movement
- d) Shift to Western medicine as sole legitimate system

Answer: _____

Short Answer

5. Compare the theoretical basis of cupping in TCM versus the Islamic scholarly tradition:

6. Why is source criticism important when evaluating historical claims about cupping?

7. What does the modern revival of Hijama require beyond traditional knowledge?

Module 2 Summary: Key Facts

#	Key Fact
1	Ebers Papyrus (c. 1550 BCE) —earliest written record of cupping
2	Hippocratic Corpus (5th–4th c. BCE) —systematic clinical approach
3	TCM (281 CE onwards) —integration with meridian theory
4	Islamic Golden Age —most comprehensive scholarly contributions
5	Ibn Sina’ s Canon —cupping indications and contraindications
6	Ibn al-Qayyim’ s Zad al-Ma’ ad —foundational text for Hijama
7	Colonial period caused massive loss of traditional medical knowledge
8	2022: 177 RCTs confirm evidence for pain conditions
9	Contemporary Hijama requires evidence-informed professionalism
10	SRA continues the scholarly tradition of source verification and clinical observation

Further Reading

Islamic Sources:

- Ibn al-Qayyim al-Jawziyya, *Zad al-Ma’ad fi Hadyi Khayr al-’Ibad* — Available in Arabic; selected translations in English
- Ibn Sina, *Al-Qanun fi al-Tibb* (The Canon of Medicine) — Gruner translation

Historical Sources:

- Nunn, J.F. (2002). *Ancient Egyptian Medicine*. University of Oklahoma Press
- Unschuld, P.U. (1985). *Medicine in China: A History of Ideas*. University of California Press
- Siraisi, N.G. (1990). *Medieval and Early Renaissance Medicine*. University of Chicago Press

Contemporary Sources:

- Cramer et al. (2022). Systematic review of cupping therapy (PMID: 35180526)
- SRA Historical Timeline (available on SRA Community platform)

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